Aki Fukai

Freelance Lead Product Designer & UX Architect

Based in Hamburg
Hybrid: Berlin · Ffm · Zurich
Remote: EWR · US/Canada East Coast
Swiss Citizen

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Engagement Model

- Freelance Lead UX & UI Architect
  B2B Retainer Contracts (3–18 months)

Design System & Architecture Capabilities

- Commerce ecosystem architecture
- Checkout & order lifecycle design
- Multi-tenant & white-label systems
- Cross-device component frameworks
- Token-based theming & UI libraries
- Design-to-code engineering collaboration
- Governance for growing product teams

Typical scope within retail digital transformation:

- E-commerce relaunch or restructuring
- Omnichannel architecture
- Checkout & payment optimisation
- Design system foundation & governance
- Mobile commerce scaling
- Platform consolidation initiatives

Languages

- German: Mother tongue
  English: Full professional proficiency
  French: Intermediate level (B1)
  Japanese & Zulu: Beginner level

Education

HAW Hamburg University of Applied Sciences, Faculty of Design
Communication design

Lead Product Designer with 20+ years of experience designing scalable retail, mobile and e-commerce systems for enterprise organisations and digital transformation.

Specialised in **UX architecture and UI design systems** for complex product ecosystems — including AI-assisted multi-device commerce flows, white-label platforms, role-based systems, and highly configurable enterprise solutions.

Focus Areas: UX architecture for mobile & e-commerce platforms · Checkout & payment system design · White-label & multi-tenant systems · Scalable design systems · Omnichannel retail ecosystems (web, mobile, POS, back office) · Complex product configuration logic

Selected Engagements

Senior Product Designer, enfore AG · E-commerce / ERP system / Mobile, Web, POS
Founding Interaction Designer, collectAI (Otto Group) · FinTech / Payments / Mobile, Web / AI
Senior UX Architect, Babymarkt · UX audit / Mobile and Web
Senior UX Designer, Immonet · Real Estate Faceted Search UX (mobile/web)
UX Concept & Design Lead, Telefónica o2 · Relaunch
Senior/Lead Interaction Designer, Rossmann · Relaunch online shop, corporate site, career portal
Co-Founder & Principal Designer, Hello Meet · Social scheduling product / C2B / Mobile

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Freelance Lead Product Designer, various clients

Jan 2022 – Present · 4 years 2 months · Freelance (part-time) · Remote

Strategic and hands-on UX/UI leadership from continuous discovery to delivery. Responsible for UX strategy, product architecture, and validation cycles in close collaboration with CPOs and tech leads. Selected clients include Babymarkt, a PropTech startup, a care platform, 1komma5°, Tagesspiegel Media, Mercedes-Benz.

References: *Patrick Koegel, Founder & CPO @ SDGventure, further clients upon request*

Lead Product Designer, whatever.works (JobRad Venture)

May 2023 – Jun 2024 · 1 year 2 months · Freelance (B2B contract) · Remote
HR Tech B2B SaaS platform (corporate venture)

Hands-on product design leadership from validation to MVP launch in close partnership with Interim CPO and Tech Lead.

Impact & End-to-End Design Leadership:

- **70-day MVP:** From early idea validation to MVP launch in 70 days
- **Product-Market Fit:** UX architecture and UI design system enabled scaling to 30+ B2B clients
- **Compliant UX Architecture:** Streamlined user flows for 150+ countries
- **Technical Integration:** Localisation (Lokalise), RBAC, SSO, account customisations, HRIS API integr.
- **Design System:** Scalable architecture enabled rapid feature development and client customisation
- **Team Building:** Hired, onboarded design talent within 1 week; mentored toward higher ownership
- **Alignment:** Engaged stakeholders across functions ensuring product and UX strategy buy-in
- **Award Recognition:** Contributed to "Best HR Startup 2023" award

Reference: *Uwe Michaelis, Founder & Managing Director @ WHATEVER.WORKS*

Lead Product Designer, PlasticPlan (Henkel Venture)

Feb – Jul 2022 · 6 months · Freelance (B2B contract) · Remote
AI-powered sustainability compliance SaaS for circular economy

Designed scalable enterprise system architecture for high-volume AI-driven data processing and multi-role workflows.

Enterprise Impact & Validation:

- **Cost Efficiency:** UX/UI design enabled up to 80% AI-driven reduction in plastic tax reporting costs
- **Data Scale:** 236M+ data points processed, 800K+ packaging comp., 160K+ products classified
- **AI-UX Integration:** Turned AI data checks into actionable UI with low cognitive and interaction cost
- **UX Coherence:** Coherent UX/UI in German and English incl. microcopy
- **Design System:** Scalable component driven UI systems for operational efficiency
- Role-based dashboards & reporting architecture

Reference: *Dr. Nora Mundschenk, Corporate Director Global Tax @ Henkel*

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Senior Product Designer, enfore AG

Jun 2018 – May 2020 · 1 year 11 months · Hamburg (Hybrid)
Initially Freelance (B2B), later permanent role
ERP and POS SaaS platform for retail, hospitality, beauty and service

Led UX architecture and design for retail and hospitality POS/ERP ecosystem serving SMEs. Delivered comprehensive modules including reservations, pick-up & delivery, online presence, business documents, a modular KPI dashboard and dashboard widgets.

Key Contributions:

- Integrated On/Offline Commerce: End-to-end online presence architecture (mobile, web and POS)
- SME-Focused UX: Simplified complex ERP processes for non-technical business users
- UX Architecture: Developed robust service blueprints to support fragmented, real-life user journeys with rapid context shifts and multi-role handovers
- Modular Design Systems: Scaled architecture for complex multi-device workflows across multiple verticals (gastronomy, retail, beauty salons, services, e-commerce)
- Engineering Partnership: Ensured design QA and performance throughout development cycles

Reference: *Christophe Stoll, Head of Design @ Enfore's internal design studio – small is beautiful*

Co-Founder & Principal Designer, Hello Meet — Group Scheduling

Jan 2018 – Mar 2024 · 6 years 3 months · Hamburg/Remote
Initially part-time, full-time Jun 2020 – Dec 2021
Group scheduling product (mobile app) and social network platform

Co-founded an uncompromisingly user-centric scheduling platform challenging traditional group scheduling models and ad-tech driven social networks. Led the complete product design from early concepts and business model design through multiple product iterations.

Strategic Contributions:

- Product Architecture: JTBD-based UX strategy with hypothesis-driven validation cycles
- Cross-Platform Systems: Designed and maintained UI & design systems across iOS, Android, Web
- Product Development: Led end-to-end feature delivery using our assumption mapping method and drove continuous improvements through user-centred insights
- Innovation Model: Pioneered C2B approach disrupting traditional enterprise scheduling workflows

Founding Interaction Designer, collectAI (Part of Otto Group)

Feb 2016 – Feb 2018 · 1 year 11 months · Hamburg (on-site)
Initially Freelance (B2B), later permanent role
FinTech B2B2C receivables automation SaaS

Led the UX and UI design as the founding product designer to create a customer centric collections platform. Designed highly configurable white-label self-service payment and debt-resolution flows for enterprise clients including OTTO, Hanseatic Bank, and eprimo.

Impact & Focus Areas:

- Traction: Crafted the product design that scaled receivables management to €25M in 18 months
- White-Label Architecture: Modular B2C payment journeys supporting enterprise clients
- Payment Journey Optimisation: Self-service flows reducing customer service dependencies
- AI-driven personalised UX: Configurable intelligent communication logic and payment plans
- Regulatory Compliance: Receivables management workflows within strict financial and GDPR rules

Reference: *Michael Backes, Co-Founder & CTO @ collectAI*

Lead Interaction Designer, SBB Swiss Federal Railways (IVEG)

Nov 2015 – Sep 2016 · 11 months · Freelance (B2B contract) · Bern, Switzerland (on-site > hybrid)
Enterprise GIS / Infrastructure SaaS · Public Sector

Digitised field-service-to-back-office workflows for vegetation risk assessment (iPad/web).

Technical Integration:

- Service Design Workshops: Complete workflow mapping from field assessment to procurement
- Component Library: UI systems aligned with SBB corporate identity across iOS and web
- Stakeholder Complexity: Public sector hierarchy alignment through iterative design workshops

Reference: *Simon Haesler, Product Owner & GIS Specialist @ SBB CFF FFS*

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Senior Interaction Designer, frog for Siemens/Unify

Sep 2013 – Jan 2014 · 5-month contract · Munich (on-site)
Enterprise Communications / Cloud-Based Team Collaboration SaaS

Designed the real-time collaboration experience design for “Project Ansible” (productised as Circuit) with frog Munich in close collaboration with the product leads and lead software architects from Unify. Ensured seamless cross-platform consistency across mobile, web, and tablet for multi-modal enterprise communication requirements.

Reference: *Justin Maguire III, Executive Creative Director @ frog Munich*

Further Selected Freelance Engagements

UX Architecture & Concept · UX Consulting · Design Systems & Brand

PropTech Platform Startup brand identity (web) · 2025
Care Platform Product discovery roadmap (mobile app) · 2025
1komma5° Design system consulting · 2024
Mercedes-Benz Design system refactoring · 2022-2023
Babymarkt UX audit (mobile app/web) · 2022
Telefónica o2 Relaunch o2online.de · 2011
CTS Eventim Relaunch eventim.de · 2008
Rossmann Relaunch online shop, corporate site, career portal · 2008-2012